

## Grim report on Mass. primary care

More patients stymied by shortages as physicians turn from basic role

By Jessica Bartlett  
GLOBE STAFF

Despite Massachusetts having many of the most sought-after physicians in the world, the most basic form of medical practice, primary care, is badly broken here for both patients and providers, state officials said in an alarming new report this week.

Among the problems singled

out by the Health Policy Commission in its report Thursday: higher numbers of patients reporting difficulty accessing primary care; an aging and increasingly dissatisfied physician workforce; and an anemic pipeline of new clinicians.

“I worry when I look at some of this data that the state of primary care has crossed a line from which recovery will be very

difficult, unless we take action soon,” the commission’s executive director, David Seltz, said in an interview.

Patients are feeling the strain. Ann Rogers-Brigham said she called a large health care system four times for an appointment with a new primary care doctor close to her work in Methuen, but struggled to find one in a convenient location or with waits shorter than a year.

She finally found a provider this month and scheduled a wellness visit — in September.

She added that she’s also been told she may get into primary care sooner if she were ill and got a referral from an urgent care center. “It’s almost like you have to be really sick and have a problem to get in,” Rogers-Brigham said.

Under a new health care law, a 25-member primary care task force is charged with reviewing reimbursement and recruitments within the workforce, and establishing a target for how much insurers should spend on

**DOCTORS, Page A10**

Massachusetts has the highest per capita spending on lottery tickets in the country, at about \$839 per resident. Last fiscal year, the lottery had nearly \$6.17 billion in revenue, but 38 communities collectively received nearly \$6.1 million last year despite not selling any lottery tickets.

## Not spreading the wealth



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Communities that spend big on the lottery don’t get the biggest return

By Esmy Jimenez  
GLOBE STAFF

For years, the Massachusetts State Lottery has been criticized for preying on low-income people by dangling the prospect of instant riches that only a very few will ever see.

But there is an equally big dose of inequity in how Massachusetts doles out the hundreds of millions it collects from the sale of lottery tickets: Low-income communities get back far less in state aid than their residents spend on the lottery, contrary to the original idea behind the lottery that poorer towns would benefit the most.

And repeated attempts to fix the system on Beacon Hill have gone for naught.

In Chelsea, for example, a predominantly Latino city with a median household income of about \$72,000, vendors sold more than \$50 million in tickets in 2023, but the city only received around \$9.5 million, or roughly 18 percent of its sales. And in Brockton, a predominantly Black city with a similar household income, residents spent more than \$120 million on lottery tickets, the fifth highest in the state. The city received roughly \$24 million.

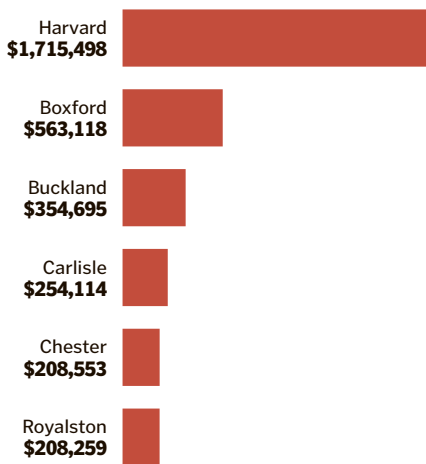
Meanwhile, the rural town of Harvard in Worcester County, with a median household income of \$200,000, received nearly \$2 million

**LOTTERY, Page A6**

Lilian San Juan scratched an instant lottery ticket at Family Market in Chelsea. “We all have a dream,” she said.

### Some towns don't sell lottery tickets, but still receive lottery fund aid

Lottery aid received in fiscal year 2023



SOURCE: Massachusetts State Lottery  
VINCE DIXON/GLOBE STAFF

## Cease-fire in Gaza to start on Sunday

Cabinet vote paves way for hostages release

By Aaron Boxerman,  
Rawan Sheikh Ahmad,  
Johnatan Reiss, Ephrat Livni, and Adam Rasgon  
NEW YORK TIMES

JERUSALEM — The Israeli government approved a cease-fire deal with Hamas early Saturday that calls for the release of dozens of hostages and hundreds of Palestinian prisoners after hours of deliberations, setting up a reprieve in the 15-month, devastating war in the Gaza Strip.

The Israeli prime minister’s office, which announced the agreement after the full

Cabinet voted, said the deal would go into effect Sunday.

Palestinians have celebrated the provisional cease-fire with the hope that it will finally end the conflict, and Israelis are anxiously awaiting the return of scores of captives abducted by Hamas.

Daniel Lifshitz, whose grandfather Oded, 84, was among the 250 captives taken in the Hamas-led attack on Israel on Oct. 7, 2023, said, “The stomach is turning, and the heart is poured out on the floor, but it’s what we’ve been waiting for.”

The initial attack killed about 1,200 people, setting off a wave of bombardments by Israel that has killed more than 46,000 Palestinians, according to the United Nations.

**CEASE-FIRE, Page A5**

## Some Biden-era rules could last

‘Republicans hate junk fees as much as Democrats’

By Sam Brodey  
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — They’re some of the most universally loathed consumer experiences in today’s economy: endless hoops to cancel a gym membership, concert tickets with hefty fees tacked on at check-out, fighting an airline when your flight is canceled or significantly delayed.

Over the last two years, President Biden’s administration has implemented new regulations intended to put an end to these common consumer headaches and several other corporate practices seen as ex-

ploitative.

Quietly and gradually, these consumer protection efforts have emerged as one of the most significant policy legacies of Biden’s presidency. The question now is whether this ambitious new regime of rules can survive the second administration of Donald Trump.

As he did during his first term, Trump is certain to reverse many federal rules enacted by Biden, particularly those with little public buy-in and considerable corporate opposition.

When it comes to rules targeted at protecting consumers from companies’ most onerous practices, however, the president-elect’s team might be inclined to continue enforcing

**RULES, Page A7**

**President Biden commuted the sentences of nearly 2,500 inmates serving long prison terms for nonviolent drug offenses. A2.**

highlighting the risks of having any ties to the opposition in Russia. **A4.**

**Three lawyers for Russian opposition leader Alexei Navalny were sentenced to prison, highlighting the risks of having any ties to the opposition in Russia. A4.**

**A prominent Harvard-trained rheumatologist pleaded not guilty to criminal charges that he raped two former patients. B1.**

### TIKTOK COUNTDOWN



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI/GETTY IMAGES

Jacob Smith recorded himself speaking about the TikTok ban outside the Supreme Court on Friday and urging his followers to stick with him. The court upheld a law that effectively bans the wildly popular app in the United States starting on Sunday. President-elect Donald Trump has vowed to “save” it. **A2.**

### Sol searching

**Saturday:** Cloudy, breezy. High: 40-45. Low: 34-39.

**Sunday:** Snow possible. High: 39-44. Low: 15-20.

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## It’s golf. In the winter. In Massachusetts.

Indoor simulators, including for the pros, proving to be a game-changer



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

Katherine Zanchi of Gloucester took a swing during a women’s league night at Harbor 9 Golf.

By Billy Baker  
GLOBE STAFF

GLOUCESTER — On a bitterly cold night in January, inside a nondescript storefront at a Gloucester strip mall, dozens of men are standing around drinking beers, screaming at giant screens, and participating in a golf revolution.

“Sit! Sit!” one of the guys shouts. The gathering is a men’s league night at Harbor 9 Golf and Sports Bar, and the golfer has just smashed an iron shot into a screen and is watching a digital line trace his shot toward the green on a simulated hole, where it lands and starts rolling toward a virtual cup.

“Get in the hole!” he shouts. “Get in the hole!”

It’s the winter of golf in Massachusetts and just about everywhere else, thanks to an explosion of golf simulators, both in homes and in retail establishments such as Harbor 9, which are popping up everywhere. On top of that, there’s a brand-new professional simulator league on ESPN, the TGL, that features some of the game’s biggest stars, such as Tiger Woods and Rory McIlroy.

In Massachusetts, where golfers have long had to hop on a

**GOLF, Page A10**